

American Idle

Just as too much sunlight takes away the sheen of the phenom called Barack Obama, a good question to ask is: who has changed more, the President or the world—or we the global audience? A little more than a year ago, he was America's catharsis, and the world's bestselling fairytale (Bill Clinton said it first and was appropriately punished for his ungraciousness on the liberal op-ed pages.) Candidate Obama turned a word as simple and banal (certainly in politics-as-usual) as 'change' into a weapon of mass seduction. He was Hope assembled from the wreckage of Bushism, and for once, the biography of a candidate became the narrative of national redemption. Today, the story of President Obama is a liberating experience only for the faithful who still desperately need a non-Bush to believe in (and that is why the arbiters in Oslo have chosen him as the Nobel Peace laureate.) In just one year, the great reconciler has become the president of triangulation. It is not that he, the most powerful politician on earth, doesn't have a battlefield or a battle plan. He has several. At home, it is health care, his New Deal, his socialist ticket to history. Elsewhere, it is the "dumb" war of Mesopotamia. Or the "necessary" war of Afghanistan. Or the mullahdom of Persia. Or the Hermit Kingdom of Asia. Or the entire Middle East for that matter. But there is a history-shifting difference: Obama has no enemies. There is no Manichean division of the world for this President, though he is yet to declare, "It's the morality, stupid!"

So, even as he sends more troops to Afghanistan, beware: America doesn't see the Taliban as eternal enemy. Washington may have problems with Iran, and Tehran may be the site of an Islamic edition of Tiananmen Square, but the Ahmadinejads of this world will have a receptive listener in the White House. Aficionados of multiculturalism will find here the first draft of a post-Bush, post-imperial weltanschauung: inclusive and sensitive. No more nation building, no more projects in freedom, for the world is too complex, too culturally nuanced to be straitjacketed in such neocon fear phraseologies like the "axis of evil". Really? Or, is it the manifestation of a muddleheaded presidency? In the new graveyard scene in geopolitics, our Hamlet doesn't hold a skull but a globe as he soliloquizes. Let us get real: every country has a stake in the American presidency, and it's his world-view that makes or unmakes an American president in this age. And no other country has the inherent power or attitude to be the global leader. China will never be one; it is so inward looking. Europe will never be nationally united, in spite of Brussels. The post-War history of the world is mostly shaped by the American presidential impulses, for better or worse. President Obama has the historic context, but his text is a moral abdication in poetry.

SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com



SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Actor **Bina Rai**, who debuted with *Kali Ghata* in 1951 and starred in films like *Anarkali*, *Taj Mahal* and *Ghungat*. She won the Filmfare Award for Best Actress for *Ghungat* in 1960.

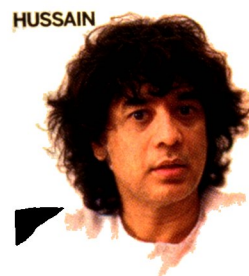


DIED: The country's first female Dalit Mayor **Aruna Sainya**, 45. She was also the first woman mayor of the Gwalior Municipal Corporation from 1995 to 2000.

DIED: Marathi writer and columnist **Sushila Hemantkumar Gupte**, 91. She was the older sister of Shiv Sena chief Bal Thackeray.

NOMINATED: Tabla Maestro **Ustad Zakir Hussain** for the 2010 Grammy Awards in the Best Classical Crossover album category for the album *The Melody of Rhythm*. Sarod maestro **Ustad Amjad Ali Khan** and Oscar-winning composer **A.R. Rahman** have also bagged Grammy nominations.

HUSSAIN



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